

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1996-03-14

To an individual b ahá'í

dear b ahá'í friend,

. . . you express disquiet that attempts being made to introduce a distinction between "b ahá'í laymen" and "b ahá'í scholars" with respect to the study of the faith tend to generate a spirit of disunity among the friends. your concern is fully justified. Such an approach to the study of the cause would betray a fundamental misunderstanding of the pattern of bahá'í society as set out in the Teachings of the faith.

As you know, bahá'u'lláh says that the pursuit of knowledge has been enjoined upon everyone, and knowledge itself is described by him as "wings to man's life" and "a ladder for his ascent."²¹⁵⁻¹ Those whose high attainments in this respect make it possible for them to contribute in important ways to the advancement of civilization are deserving of society's recognition and gratitude.

in the study of the revelation of god, an individual's proficiency in one of the physical or social sciences, in law, philology, or other fields of specialization will often throw valuable light on issues being examined, and such contributions are greatly to be appreciated. The field of Near east studies, mentioned in your letter, is one that can assist in this way. however, no one specialization among the many branches of scholarly research can confer upon its practitioners an authoritative role in the common effort of exploring the implications of so staggering and all-encompassing a body of truth.

²¹⁵⁻¹. eSw , p. 26.^{214.3}

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^{215.3}

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76collateral with his summons to the pursuit of knowledge, bahá'u'lláh

has abolished entirely that feature of all past religions by which a special caste of persons such as the christian priesthood or the islamic 'ulamá came to exercise authority over the religious understanding and practice of their fellow believers. in a letter written in persian on his behalf to the Spiritual Assembly of the bahá'ís of istanbul, the guardian is at some pains to underline the importance of this marked departure from past religious history: but praise be to god that the pen of glory has done away with the unyielding and dictatorial views of the learned and the wise, dismissed the assertions of individuals as an authoritative criterion, even though they were recognized as the most accomplished and learned among men, and ordained that all matters be referred to authorized centers and specified assemblies.

The bahá'í dispensation is described in the words of its founder as

“a day that shall not be followed by night.”

215-2 Through his covenant,

bahá'u'lláh has provided an unfailing source of divine guidance that will endure throughout the dispensation. Authority to administer the affairs of the community and to ensure both the integrity of the word of god and the promotion of the faith's message is conferred upon the Administrative order to which the covenant has given birth. it is solely by the process of free election or by unsought appointment that the members of the institutions of this order are assigned to their positions in it. There is no profession in either the teaching of the faith or its administration for which one can train or to which a believer can properly aspire. cautionary words of bahá'u'lláh are particularly relevant:

ever since the seeking of preference and distinction came into play, the world has been laid waste. i t has become desolate. . . .

indeed, man is noble, inasmuch as each one is a repository of the sign of god. Nevertheless, to regard oneself as superior in knowledge, learning or virtue, or to exalt oneself or seek preference is a grievous transgression.

215-2. Sh, ¶63.215.4

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77The promotion of learning of every kind among the faith's members is an activity fundamental to the achievement of the community's wide-ranging goals. consequently, the encouragement of individual believers to acquire knowledge, the operation of bahá'í schools, universities, and training institutes, the organization of study groups, and the work of task forces dedicated to relating the principles of the revelation to the challenges facing humankind all represent activities with which both the counselors and their auxiliaries, on the one hand, and National and local Spiritual Assemblies, on the other, must concern themselves. in shouldering these demanding responsibilities, bahá'í institutions everywhere find their efforts greatly enhanced by the assistance of believers whose intellectual pursuits, qualities of character, and devotion to the cause particularly fit them to contribute their services.

A special responsibility in the matter rests on the counselors because of the duty assigned to them to assist in releasing the potential of the individual believer. The members of this institution, appointed for specific terms, have been given the task of carrying forward into the future the functions of the protection and propagation of the faith conferred in the will and Testament of 'Abdu'l-bahá on the hands of the cause. Thus, the counselors are called on to "diffuse the divine fragrances, to edify the souls of men, to promote learning, to improve the character of all men and to be, at all times and under all conditions, sanctified and detached from earthly things."

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like the hands, the counselors have no interpretive authority, an authority conferred by the covenant only on 'Abdu'l-bahá and the guardian of the faith. while some counselors, like some of the hands, will have pursued various academic or professional disciplines in their individual careers, their discharge of their duties is not dependent on proficiencies of this kind. All of them share fully in the vital task of encouraging believers everywhere in the acquisition of knowledge, in all its dimensions. All share, too, in the responsibility assigned to the institution of which they are members to protect the faith against its enemies,

both external and internal, a concern to which

both the master and the guardian attached preeminent importance. . . .

with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

215-3. bA, p. 8.215.6

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The Four Year Plan

Message from The Universal House of Justice

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Ridván Message 1996

Ridván 153

To the bahá'ís of the world

dearly loved friends,

our hearts overflowing with gratitude to the blessed beauty, we acknowledge the abundant manifestations of his grace during the Three year plan, which has run its course with the advent of this Ridván festival. The animating spirit of the holy year, which lent impetus to the launching of the plan at Ridván 1993, pervaded this period of concentrated endeavor, rendering our world community more consolidated, more resilient, more mature, and more confident than before. At the same time, the community's prestige attained new heights. While this plan has not ended on a note of dramatic, numerical expansion, even though significant growth of membership occurred in various countries, it has nonetheless resulted in a qualitatively enriched community—one prepared to exploit the immediate prospects for the advancement of the faith.

The magnificent progress of the projects on Mount Carmel is preeminent among the measurable achievements of this period. Indeed, despite numerous difficulties, the stage of accomplishment anticipated in our message announcing the Three year plan is entirely evident. All phases of construction have been initiated. The structural framework of the center for the Study of the Texts and the extension to the international Archives building has been raised up and the work on these buildings has advanced towards initiation of the exterior and interior finishing work. The erection of the permanent seat of the international Teaching

center, the third structure currently be-

ing built on the Arc, is progressing rapidly. Seven terraces below the Shrine of the báb are now completed, foreshowing the unfolding splendor from

the foot to the ridge of god's holy mountain. A watchful public is awed at

the tapestry of beauty spreading over the mountainside.

The physical reality of the progress thus far so marvelously realized is

proof of an even more profound achievement, namely, the unity of purpose effected throughout our global community in the pursuit of this gigantic, collective enterprise. The intensity of the interest and support it has evoked

has expressed itself in an unprecedented outpouring of contributions, re-

flecting a level of sacrifice that bespeaks the quality of faith and generosity 216.1

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81of heart of bahá'u'lláh's lovers throughout the planet. That contributions

towards the mount carmel projects have met the three-year goal of seventy-

four million dollars marks yet another measurable and exceptional achieve-

ment, inspiring confidence that the necessary financial support for these projects will continue until their completion by the end of the century.

The signs of progress during the past three years were evident in a wide

and varied field. The remarkable efforts to expand and consolidate the com-munity, the increased ventures in social and economic development, and the unprecedented thrust of the external affairs work combine to portray a community endowed with new capacities.

in the arena of teaching, there was a general increase of activity as indi-

cated by the formation of twelve new National Spiritual Assemblies during the course of the plan and by the surge of pioneering and travel-teaching.

believers in many countries were galvanized by the fresh approach suggested

in the pioneer call released during the plan. The number of pioneers from

and to various countries was high, and there was a veritable flood of travel-ing teachers operating both at home and abroad. Systematic approaches

to collective teaching activities and well-focused long-term teaching proj-

ects were fruitful and were more evident than ever before in a number of

countries.

The energy and creativity attendant to the various developments in ex-

pansion and consolidation owed much to the spirit of enterprise shown by the international Teaching center. its constant direction and encour-

agement of the continental boards of counselors; its recommendation of new methods for the deployment of pioneers, as endorsed by the universal house of justice in the pioneer call released in the early months of the plan, and its regular assistance to the continental pioneer committees placed in its charge; its unflagging attention to the educational needs of the community as expressed in its interactions with counselors concerning the inclusion in teaching projects of deepening programs for new believers, the devising of courses and workshops for training in different capacities, the training of children's teachers, and the multiplication of children's classes; its stimulation of efforts to establish training institutes in different parts of the world—all have produced resounding results. major credit must also go to the Teaching center for the influence it exerted through the counselors on the adoption of core literature programs in an increasing number of countries. Through such programs a few titles essential to the propagation of the faith and the deepening of the believers were selected, printed in large 216.4

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82 quantities and made available at reduced prices. The outstanding progress in the evolution of this vital institution operating at the world center was palpable in its preparation and conduct of the counselors' conference last december which set the course for the work of these high-ranking officers of the f aith during the immediate years ahead.

A relevant development was the notable rise in the assumption of responsibility by indigenous believers for the teaching and consolidation work in their own countries. in greatly troubled areas, such as Angola, cambodia, liberia, Sierra leone, the friends claimed important victories, whether in pursuing teaching activities which resulted in numerically significant enrollments, or in establishing and reactivating bahá'í Assemblies, or in initiating and sustaining development projects. in places with recently formed National Spiritual Assemblies, such as countries of the former eastern bloc, the friends have shown an admirable capacity for administering the affairs of the cause. A highlight of this period was the upsurge of vigor, courage and creativity in bahá'í island communities throughout the world.

The categories of activity were wide-ranging, involving the raising up of local teachers, the training and dispatch of scores of traveling teachers to neighboring islands, the inauguration of primary schools, the multiple occasions for proclamation of the faith, the sponsorship of events attended by high-ranking officials and influential persons. The fact that in recent years a number of government leaders of island nations have visited the bahá'í world center is indicative of the vitality of the activities of the believers in these small lands scattered throughout the seven seas. Taken together, all the foregoing examples of the attitudes and efforts of the friends in different settings demonstrate a heightened commitment to the teaching work and a growing maturity and resilience reflective of the depth of faith motivating bahá'ís from diverse populations.

consonant with these observations were the outstanding contributions of the youth to expansion and consolidation. Their activities took on added dimensions during the three-year period. Actuated by youth conferences and other gatherings attentive to their interests, youth throughout the world invested immense amounts of time, energy and zeal in the teaching work as traveling teachers within and outside their countries and as teams in collective teaching projects and, in so doing, they stimulated hundreds of new enrollments and the formation of many local Spiritual Assemblies; involvement of youth in music and the arts as a means of proclaiming and teaching the cause distinguished their exertions in many places; the spread

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8 of dance and drama workshops was particularly effective; participation of youth in external affairs opened new possibilities for the faith in this field; commitment to a year of service was more widely demonstrated; at the same time there was a notable increase in the number of youth acquiring formal training and achieving academic, professional and vocational excellence—altogether an indication that the youth are doing more in direct service to the faith while at the same time contributing to the general development of society.

Signs of the consolidation of the community were also discernible in the greater involvement of the friends in social and economic development, particularly in the field of education. in one outstanding instance, a government asked the bahá'ís to take responsibility for the management of seven public schools, and they did so with the backing of the office of

Social and economic development at the world center. worthy of note is that in Africa bahá'í communities in exile because of political unrest in their home country continued to develop farming and other projects that went far towards ensuring self-sufficiency. efforts at improving the status of women gathered momentum in a number of countries where, in addition to bahá'í participation in projects sponsored by other organizations, the bahá'í institutions set up committees and offices to attend to the interests of women. The bahá'í international community's office for the Advancement of women emerged as a symbol of this upswing.

in a number of countries, too, there was significant bahá'í participation in government-sponsored programs to improve health; in other instances bahá'í groups initiated such programs and carried them out. The work in social and economic development was also distinguished by the firm establishment and consolidation of a number of major projects and organizations. Three pilot literacy projects were begun as a first step in a literacy campaign which the office of Social and economic development intends to extend throughout the world. The bahá'í initiation and involvement in development projects also resulted in proclamation of the faith as they attracted the participation of the public and the interest of mass media.

A thrust in the external affairs work exceeding all previous records for a similar period boosted the proclamation of the cause. A prodigy of effort in all parts of the world redounded to a much greater visibility of the faith than obtained before and to a consequent rise in the prestige of the bahá'í international community. The broad lines of progress were evident in the ease with which bahá'í communities, large and small, sponsored or partici-

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8pated in public events; in the emergence of the bahá'ís as a force in society recognized by governmental and nongovernmental organizations and many prominent persons; in the ready accessibility of the media. indeed, the wide coverage accorded bahá'í events and interests by the print and electronic communications media was beyond calculation.

in the sweep of activities throughout the world, certain specific devel-

opments stood out: the frequency with which high public officials would invite bahá'ís to participate in or assist with events or projects; the successful initiatives of bahá'ís in influencing government action; the establishment of bahá'í academic programs and courses in colleges and universities and the adoption of curricular material for public schools; the use of the arts by bahá'í institutions, groups and individuals in proclamation events.

during 1995, two major united Nations events exemplified the gathering momentum of an emerging unity of thought in world undertakings, and these engaged the active attention and participation of the bahá'í community. first, the world Summit for Social development in copenhagen during march involved 250 friends from more than 40 countries who mounted an impressive effort to acquaint the summit participants and the related Ngo forum with the Teachings. it was on this occasion that the statement The Prosperity of Humankind, produced by the bahá'í international community's office of public information, was first distributed and discussed. follow-up activities all over the world included the holding of conferences and seminars, as well as the distribution of the statement. Sec-ond, the fourth world conference on women and the concomitant Ngo forum held in beijing during September drew the attendance of more than 500 bahá'ís from around the world, in addition to the official delegation of the bahá'í international community. in that same year, a third event, the observance of the fiftieth Anniversary of the united Nations, prompted the bahá'í international community's united Nations office to produce and distribute a statement, entitled "Turning point for All Nations,"

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ing proposals for the development of that world organization.

Also of particular note among the external affairs activities were two occasions involving the prominent participation of Amatu'l-bahá Rúḡíyyih khánúm. last spring she headed the delegation of the four official bahá'í

216-1. The text of the statement is available online at <http://www.ibiblio.org/bahai/Texts/english/Turning-point-for-All-Nations.html>.216.12

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85representatives to the Summit on the Alliance between religions and conservation, patronized by his royal highness prince philip and held at windsor castle. during october rú'íyyih khánum was the keynote speaker at the fourth international dialogue on the T ransition to global Society held under the auspices of the united Nations educational, Scientific, and cultural organization (uNeSco) and organized by the bahá'í chair for world peace and the department of history at the university of maryland.

Nor can we neglect to mention certain other significant marks of the period under review. An edition of the kitáb-i-Aqdas in the original Arabic was published with, for the first time, notes in persian, supplementing the text as in the english edition. The law of þuqúqu'lláh became more deeply rooted in the hearts of the believers throughout the world, and during the final year of the plan, the T rustee of þuqúqu'lláh, hand of the cause of god 'Alí-m uẖammad varqá, took up residence in the holy land. This significant step also means that all three hands of the cause of god—Amatu'l-bahá rú'íyyih khánum, mr. 'Alí-Akbar furútan, and dr. varqá—are now residing at the world center, bringing inspiration to pilgrims and visitors, and to the friends serving at the world center.

it is against such a background of heartening developments that we embark at this riṣván upon a four year plan that will carry us to riṣván 2000. we earnestly and lovingly call upon our brothers and sisters of every land to join us in a mobilization of effort that will ensure to generations of the fast-approaching twenty-first century an abundant and lasting legacy.

The four year plan aims at one major accomplishment: a significant advance in the process of entry by troops. As we have stated earlier, such an advance is to be achieved through marked progress in the activity and development of the individual believer, of the institutions, and of the local community.

The phrase “advance in the process of entry by troops” accommodates the concept that current circumstances demand and existing opportunities allow for a sustained growth of the bahá'í world community on a large scale; that this upsurge is necessary in the face of world conditions; that the three constituent participants in the upbuilding of the order of bahá'u'lláh—the

individual, the institutions, and the community—can foster such growth first by spiritually and mentally accepting the possibility of it, and then by working towards embracing masses of new believers, setting in motion the means for effecting their spiritual and administrative training and development-216.15

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86ment, thereby multiplying the number of knowledgeable, active teachers and administrators whose involvement in the work of the cause will ensure a constant influx of new adherents, an uninterrupted evolution of bahá'í Assemblies, and a steady consolidation of the community.

moreover, to advance the process implies that that process is already in progress and that local and national communities are at different stages of it.

All communities are now tasked to take steps and sustain efforts to achieve a level of expansion and consolidation commensurate with their possibilities. The individual and the institutions, while operating in distinctive spheres, are summoned to arise to meet the requirements of this crucial time in the life of our community and in the fortunes of all humankind.

The role of the individual is of unique importance in the work of the cause. it is the individual who manifests the vitality of faith upon which the success of the teaching work and the development of the community depend. bahá'u'lláh's command to each believer to teach his faith confers

an inescapable responsibility which cannot be transferred to, or assumed by, any institution of the cause. The individual alone can exercise those

capacities which include the ability to take initiative, to seize opportunities, to form friendships, to interact personally with others, to build relationships, to win the cooperation of others in common service to the faith and

society, and to convert into action the decisions made by consultative bodies. it is the individual's duty to "consider every avenue of approach which he might utilize in his personal attempts to capture the attention, maintain the interest, and deepen the faith, of those whom he seeks to bring into the fold of his faith."

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To optimize the use of these capacities, the individual draws upon his

love for bahá'u'lláh, the power of the covenant, the dynamics of prayer, the inspiration and education derived from regular reading and study of the holy Texts, and the transformative forces that operate upon his soul as he strives to behave in accordance with the divine laws and principles. in addition to these, the individual, having been given the duty to teach the cause, is endowed with the capacity to attract particular blessings promised by bahá'u'lláh. "whoso openeth his lips in this day," the blessed beauty asserts, "and maketh mention of the name of his lord, the hosts of divine inspiration shall descend upon him from the heaven of my name, the All-

216-2. Adj, ¶76.216.19

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87knowing, the All-wise. on him shall also descend the concourse on high, each bearing aloft a chalice of pure light."216-3

Shoghi effendi underscored the absolute necessity of individual initiative and action. he explained that without the support of the individual, "at once wholehearted, continuous and generous," every measure and plan of his National Spiritual Assembly is "foredoomed to failure," the purpose of the master's divine plan is "impeded"; furthermore, the sustaining strength of bahá'u'lláh himself "will be withheld from every and each individual who fails in the long run to arise and play his part."

216-4 hence, at the very

crux of any progress to be made is the individual believer, who possesses the power of execution which only he can release through his own initiative and sustained action. regarding the sense of inadequacy that sometimes hampers individual initiative, a letter written on his behalf conveys the guardian's advice: "chief among these, you mention the lack of courage and of initiative on the part of the believers, and a feeling of inferiority which prevents them from addressing the public. it is precisely these weaknesses that he wishes the friends to overcome, for these do not only paralyze their efforts but actually serve to quench the flame of faith in their hearts.

Not until all the friends come to realize that every one of them is able, in his own measure, to deliver the message, can they ever hope to reach the goal

that has been set before them by a loving and wise master. . . . everyone is a potential teacher. he has only to use what god has given him and thus prove that he is faithful to his trust.”

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As for the institutions, entry by troops will act upon them as much as they will act upon it. The evolution of local and national bahá'í Assemblies at this time calls for a new state of mind on the part of their members as well as on the part of those who elect them, for the bahá'í community is engaged in an immense historical process that is entering a critical stage. bahá'u'lláh has given to the world institutions to operate in an order designed to canalize the forces of a new civilization. progress towards that glorious realization requires a great and continuous expansion of the bahá'í community, so that adequate scope is provided for the maturation of these institutions. This is a matter of immediate importance to bahá'u'lláh's avowed supporters in all lands.

216-3. gwb, no. 129.3.

216-4. cf , p. 131.

216-5. AlNz, p. 34.216.22

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88for such an expansion to be stimulated and accommodated, the Spiritual Assemblies must rise to a new stage in the exercise of their responsibilities as channels of divine guidance, planners of the teaching work, developers of human resources, builders of communities, and loving shepherds of the multitudes. They can realize these prospects through increasing the ability of their members to take counsel together in accordance with the principles of the faith and to consult with the friends under their jurisdiction, through fostering the spirit of service, through spontaneously collaborating with the continental counselors and their auxiliaries, and through cultivating their external relations. particularly must the progress in the evolution of the institutions be manifest in the multiplication of localities in which the functioning of the Spiritual Assembly enhances the individual believers' capacity to serve the cause and fosters unified action. in sum, the maturity of the Spiritual Assembly must be measured not only by the regularity of its meetings and the efficiency of its functioning, but also by the continuity of the growth of bahá'í membership, the effectiveness of the interaction be-

tween the Assembly and the members of its community, the quality of the spiritual and social life of the community, and the overall sense of vitality of a community in the process of dynamic, ever-advancing development. The community, as distinguished from the individual and the institutions, assumes its own character and identity as it grows in size. This is a necessary development to which much attention is required both with respect to places where large-scale enrollment has occurred and in anticipation of more numerous instances of entry by troops. A community is of course more than the sum of its membership; it is a comprehensive unit of civilization composed of individuals, families and institutions that are originators and encouragers of systems, agencies and organizations working together with a common purpose for the welfare of people both within and beyond its own borders; it is a composition of diverse, interacting participants that are achieving unity in an unremitting quest for spiritual and social progress. Since bahá'ís everywhere are at the very beginning of the process of community building, enormous effort must be devoted to the tasks at hand.

As we have said in an earlier message, the flourishing of the community, especially at the local level, demands a significant enhancement in patterns of behavior: those patterns by which the collective expression of the virtues of the individual members and the functioning of the Spiritual Assembly are manifest in the unity and fellowship of the community and the dynamism of its activity and growth. This calls for the integration of 216.24

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89the component elements—adults, youth and children—in spiritual, social, educational and administrative activities; and their engagement in local plans of teaching and development. it implies a collective will and sense of purpose to perpetuate the Spiritual Assembly through annual elections. it involves the practice of collective worship of god. hence, it is essential to the spiritual life of the community that the friends hold regular devotional meetings in local bahá'í centers, where available, or elsewhere, including the homes of believers.

To effect the possibilities of expansion and consolidation implied by entry by troops, a determined, worldwide effort to develop human resources must be made. The endeavor of individuals to conduct study classes in their

homes, the sponsorship by the institutions of occasional courses of instruction, and the informal activities of the community, though important, are not adequate for the education and training of a rapidly expanding community. it is therefore of paramount importance that systematic attention be given to devising methods for educating large numbers of believers in the fundamental verities of the faith and for training and assisting them to serve the cause as their god-given talents allow. There should be no delay in establishing permanent institutes designed to provide well-organized, formally conducted programs of training on a regular schedule. Access of the institute to physical facilities will of course be necessary, but it may not require a building of its own.

This matter calls for an intensification of the collaboration between the continental counselors and National Spiritual Assemblies. for the success of these training institutes will depend in very large measure on the active involvement of the continental counselors and the Auxiliary board members in their operation. particularly will it be necessary for Auxiliary board members to have a close working relationship with institutes and, of course, with the local Spiritual Assemblies whose communities will benefit from institute programs. Since institutes are to be regarded as centers of learning, and since their character harmonizes with, and provides scope for the exercise of, the educational responsibilities of the Auxiliary board members, the intimate involvement in institute operations should now become a part of the evolving functions of these officers of the faith. drawing on the talents and abilities of increasing numbers of believers will also be crucial to the development and execution of institute programs.

As the term "institute" has assumed various uses in the bahá'í community, a word of clarification is needed. The next four years will represent an

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90extraordinary period in the history of our faith, a turning point of epochal

magnitude. what the friends throughout the world are now being asked

to do is to commit themselves, their material resources, their abilities and

their time to the development of a network of training institutes on a scale never before attempted. These centers of bahá'í learning will have as their

goal one very practical outcome, namely, the raising up of large numbers of believers who are trained to foster and facilitate the process of entry by troops with efficiency and love.

“center your energies in the propagation of the faith of god,” bahá’u’lláh thus instructs his servants, adding, “ whoso is worthy of so high a calling, let him arise and promote it. whoso is unable, it is his duty to appoint him who will, in his stead, proclaim this revelation. . . .”

216-6 just as one depu-

tizes another to teach in one’s stead by covering the expenses of a pioneer or traveling teacher, one can deputize a teacher serving an institute, who is, of course, a teacher of teachers. To do so, one may make contributions to the continental bahá’í fund, as well as to the local, National and international funds, earmarked for this purpose.

in all their efforts to achieve the aim of the four year plan, the friends are also asked to give greater attention to the use of the arts, not only for proclamation, but also for the work in expansion and consolidation. The graphic and performing arts and literature have played, and can play, a major role in extending the influence of the cause. At the level of folk art, this possibility can be pursued in every part of the world, whether it be in villages, towns or cities. Shoghi effendi held high hopes for the arts as a means for attracting attention to the Teachings. A letter written on his behalf to an individual thus conveys the guardian’s view: “The day will come when the cause will spread like wildfire when its spirit and teachings will be presented on the stage or in art and literature as a whole. Art can better awaken such noble sentiments than cold rationalizing, especially among the mass of the people.”

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while the friends and institutions everywhere bend their energies to implementing the requirements of the plan, work on the great projects on mount carmel will continue towards their anticipated completion at the end of the century. by the end of the plan at rixvân 2000, the buildings

216-6. gwb, no. 96.3

216-7 . cc 1:26.216.30

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91for the center for the Study of the Texts and the extension of the Archives

building will become operational; the international Teaching center build-

ing will have advanced to the final finishing stage. The section of the public

road which now interrupts the path of the terraces above the Shrine of the báb will have been lowered and a broad connecting bridge with its own gardens will have been built; five of the upper terraces will also have been

completed. The remaining four upper terraces and the two at the foot of

the mountain will be in an advanced stage of development. other particular

efforts will be pursued at the world center as well. Attention will be given

to such matters as the universal application of additional laws of the kitáb-

i-Aqdas, the preparation of a new volume in english of selected writings of

bahá'u'lláh, the further development of the functions of the international

Teaching center, and the devising of measures for increasing the number of

pilgrims and visitors to the w orld center.

The bahá'í world community will expand its endeavors in both social

and economic development and external affairs, and thus continue to col-laborate directly with the forces leading towards the establishment of order

in the world. by improving its coordinating capacity, the office of Social

and economic development will assist in building, as resources and op-

portunity permit, on the progress already made with hundreds of devel-

opment projects around the world. in the arena of external affairs, efforts

will be aimed at influencing the processes towards world peace, particularly through the community's involvement in the promotion of human rights, the status of women, global prosperity, and moral development. in the

pursuit of these themes, the bahá'í international community's united Na-

tions office will seek ways to reinforce the ties between the bahá'ís and the

united Nations. Similarly, the office of public information will assist the

bahá'í institutions to utilize these themes towards greater proclamation of

the faith. defense of the rights of the bahá'ís in iran and increased efforts

to emancipate the faith in that country and other countries where it is

proscribed will constitute a vital part of our dealings with governments and nongovernmental organizations. in all such respects the bahá'í friends and

institutions are urged to be alert to the importance of activities in external affairs and to give renewed attention to them.

The formation this riḡvān of two National Spiritual Assemblies lends a propitious beginning to the four year plan. we are delighted to announce that our two representatives to the inaugural National conventions are the hand of the cause of god Amatu'l-b ahá rúŷíyyih khánum, moldova; 216.33
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m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

92and mr. fred Schechter, counselor member of the international Teaching center, São Tomé and príncipe. regrettably, due to circumstances entirely beyond their control, the National Spiritual Assemblies of burundi and rwanda cannot be reelected this year. The number of these institutions worldwide will consequently remain at 174.

riḡvān 2000, the point at which the four year plan is to be concluded, will come many months before the end of the twentieth century. At that juncture in time, the bahá'í world will look back in appreciation at

the extraordinary developments and dazzling achievements that will have distinguished the annals of the cause of bahá'u'lláh during that eventful

period—a period which 'Abdu'l-b ahá called the “century of light.”

216-8 Not

the least of the accomplishments then to be recognized will be the completion of the current projects on mount carmel which, together with the other edifices on that holy mountain, will stand as a monument to the progress which the Administrative order will have attained by that time in the formative Age. The highlight of such appreciations will, god willing, be the holding at the world center of a major event to mark the completion of the buildings on the Arc and the opening of the Terraces of the Shrine of the báb to the public.

beloved friends, we enter this plan amid the turbulence of a period of accelerating transition. The twin processes prompted by the impact of bahá'u'lláh's revelation are fast at work, gathering a momentum that will, in the words of Shoghi effendi, “bring to a climax the forces that are transforming the face of our planet.” one is an integrating process; the other is disruptive. out of the “universal fermentation” created by these processes, peace will emerge in stages, through which the unifying effects of a growing consciousness of world citizenship will become manifest.

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Towards that end, recent world developments have, paradoxically, been both shocking and reassuring. on one hand, the disarray of human affairs produces a daily diet of horrors that benumb the senses; on the other, world leaders are often taking collective actions that, to a bahá'í observer, signify a tendency towards a common approach by nations to solving world problems. consider, for instance, the unusual frequency of the global occasions on which these leaders have gathered since the holy year four years ago, such as the one in observance of the fiftieth Anniversary of the

216-8. pup , p. 90.

216-9. wob, p. 170.216.35

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United Nations, at which the attending heads of state and heads of government asserted their commitment to world peace. Noteworthy, too, are the promptitude and spontaneity with which these government leaders have been acting together in responding to a variety of crises in different parts of the world. Such trends coincide with the increasing cries from enlightened circles for attention to be given to the feasibility of achieving some form of global governance. might we not see in these swiftly developing occurrences the workings of the hand of providence, indeed the very harbinger of the monumental occasion forecast in our writings? even though the establishment of the lesser peace is not dependent on any bahá'í plan or action, and although it will not represent the ultimate goal humanity is destined to reach in the golden Age, our community has a responsibility to lend spiritual impetus to the processes towards that peace. The need at this exact time is to so intensify our efforts in building the bahá'í System that we will attract the confirmations of bahá'u'lláh and thus invoke a spiritual atmosphere that will accrue to the quickening of these processes. Two main challenges face us: one is to mount a campaign of teaching in which the broad membership of our community is enthusiastically, systematically and personally engaged, and in which the activation of an extensive training program will ensure the development of a mass of human resources; the other is to complete the construction projects on mount carmel towards which every sacrifice must be made to provide a liberal outpouring of material means. These twin foci, if resolutely pursued,

will foster conditions towards the release of pent-up forces that will forge a change in the direction of human affairs throughout the planet.

however short the path to peace, it will be tortuous; however promising the anticipated event that will set its course, it must mature through a long period of evolution, with its attendant tests, setbacks and conflicts, towards the moment when it will have emerged, under the direct influences of god's faith, as the most great peace. in the meantime, people everywhere will often face despair and bewilderment before arriving at an appreciation of the transition in progress. we who have been enlightened by the new revelation have the sacred word to assure us, a divine plan to guide us, a history of valor to encourage us. let us therefore take heart not only from the word we treasure, but also from the deeds of heroism and sacrifice which even today shine resplendent in the land in which our cause was born.

for some seventeen years our persecuted brethren in iran have demonstrated a constancy of faith and courage that has produced a vast proclama-

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m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

9tion of the faith, forcing it out of obscurity. here then is living evidence in our own time of the potencies of crisis and victory. please god, it may not be too long before our iranian brethren are relieved of the yoke they bear and are ushered into the glories and wonders of a victory that only the blessed beauty can bestow. Their experience is a signal and an example to us all wherever we may live; for eventually, opposition, as the master has told us, will rear its head on all the continents. Though it may be of a different character from place to place, it will no doubt be intensive. but, thanks to the strengthening grace of bahá'u'lláh and the demonstration of steadfastness by these noble friends, we shall know how to meet the shafts of the enemy without fear. indeed, the lord of hosts has promised to deliver to his people an overwhelming and decisive triumph.

As humanity is tossed and tormented by the ravages inflicted upon it by a civilization gone out of control, let us keep our heads and hearts focused on the divine tasks set before us. for amid this turmoil opportunities will

abound that must be exploited “for the purpose of spreading far and wide the knowledge of the redemptive power of the faith of bahá’u’lláh and
for enlisting fresh recruits in the ever-swelling army of his followers.”

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This plan to which we are now committed is set at one of the most critical times in the life of the planet. it is meant to prepare our community to cope with the accelerating changes that are occurring in the world about us and to place the community in a position both to withstand the weight of the accompanying tests and challenges and to make more visible a pattern of functioning to which the world can turn for aid and example in the wake of a tumultuous transition. Thus, this plan acquires a special place in the scheme of bahá’í and world history. Those of us who are alive to the vision of the faith are particularly privileged to be consciously engaged in efforts intended to stimulate and eventually enhance such processes.

may you all arise to seize the tasks of this crucial moment. may each inscribe his or her own mark on a brief span of time so charged with potentialities and hope for all humanity. lest you become distracted or preoccupied with the drastic happenings of this age of transition, bear ever in mind the advice of our infallible guide, Shoghi effendi: “Not ours, puny mortals that we are, to attempt, at so critical a stage in the long and checkered history of mankind, to arrive at a precise and satisfactory understanding of the steps

216-10. Adj, ¶73.216.41

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95which must successively lead a bleeding humanity, wretchedly oblivious of its god, and careless of bahá’u’lláh, from its calvary to its ultimate resurrection. . . . ours rather the duty, however confused the scene, however

dismal the present outlook, however circumscribed the resources we dispose of, to labor serenely, confidently, and unremittingly to lend our share of assistance, in whichever way circumstances may enable us, to the operation

of the forces which, as marshaled and directed by bahá’u’lláh, are leading humanity out of the valley of misery and shame to the loftiest summits of power and glory.”

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Supplementary Message—Ridván Message 1996—

Latin America and the Caribbean

Ridván 153

To the followers of Bahá'u'lláh in Latin America and the Caribbean
dearly loved friends,

As you contemplate the challenges awaiting you during these closing
years of the century, you may draw confidence from the knowledge that your past
endeavors have been abundantly blessed by divine confirmation. Some sixty years ago,
when the Guardian had called for the establishment
of at least one center in each of the central and South American republics,
he wrote of “the strenuous and organized labors by which future generations of believers in
the Latin countries must distinguish themselves.”

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Addressing the friends in the Caribbean some years later in a letter written
shortly after the formation of the Spiritual Assembly of the greater Antil-
les, he urged them to exert “continuous and systematic effort,” to evince “unyielding
determination” and to display “wholehearted consecration.” Your achievements during the
intervening decades have amply demon-
strated your capacity to meet his expectations. You have proved by the spirit
animating your efforts to be well deserving of such tributes as “staunch,” “warmhearted,”
“eager,” “spiritually minded.”

216-11. pup, ¶303.

217-1. Adj, ¶90.217.1

Message from The Universal House of Justice

96The central concern of the plans that will guide your endeavors during
the coming four years will be to effect a significant advance in the process
of entry by troops. This challenge you will not be facing as novices. You
have accumulated through successive plans valuable experience which must
now be brought to bear on the aim of the four year plan with clarity and
single-mindedness. Your success will depend on the degree to which you
can, on the one hand, intensify activity in the areas that have already witnessed large-scale
expansion and, on the other, exploit the fresh opportunities presented to you as a result of
your growing involvement in the affairs of society.
Your numerical strength lies in those many regions where, over the
decades, intense teaching activities have been undertaken among diverse populations.
Through these exertions, large numbers from most of the in-

indigenous tribes—singled out by ‘Abdu’l-b ahá to be the recipients of special favors and promises—as well as people of the African, Asian and European races, have enlisted under the banner of the faith. As a result, your community now boasts of a harmonious blend of groups from various ethnic and cultural backgrounds.

Plans focusing on these areas of large-scale expansion will necessarily seek to mobilize an appreciable number of believers within each population not only to labor diligently in their own local communities, but also to serve as long- and short-term pioneers and visiting teachers in other localities. Training programs, with which many of your communities have considerable experience, constitute a most potent instrument for the accomplishment of such a vast mobilization. We call upon you, then, to support the work of the training institutes in your countries, the more experienced among you giving generously of their time as teachers so that courses can be offered widely and consistently. As you acquire new knowledge and skills through these programs, you will be able to put into practice with enthusiasm and zeal what you have learned, and arise to shoulder the manifold responsibilities that accelerated expansion and consolidation demand.

This mobilization will greatly facilitate the development of local communities, a task that in the past has not been an easy one to accomplish. Your labors in this field of endeavor must now be systematically and vigorously multiplied, utilizing the valuable methods and approaches that have been devised in many of your countries in recent years. A host of dedicated workers is needed within each population who, supported by Auxiliary Board members, regional committees and institutes, focus their energies on the

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97strengthening of community after community. Let those of you who arise, even when you can find but a handful of believers in a locality, gather them together, broaden their vision, and raise their awareness of the greatness of the cause they have embraced. Help the local Spiritual Assembly to launch the community on a path of systematic expansion and consolidation, bringing in new recruits or revitalizing those who, having accepted the faith

years ago, have seen their enthusiasm wane. remember, moreover, that in this process of community building the education of children—without which the victories of a whole generation may be lost—must be given due emphasis.

while paying close attention to areas of large-scale expansion, you should not lose sight of the fact that your nations have undergone profound change over the past decades, resulting in increased receptivity to the faith in many sectors of society. you have, in each of your national communities, developed remarkable capacity to interact with society at large. Through your extensive work in social and economic development, especially in the area of education, through your discourse on issues such as the preservation of the environment and the organization of social action, through your substantive interactions with leaders of thought, you are developing a keen understanding of the needs and aspirations of your peoples which enhances your ability to present the faith to a wide range of interests.

Together with your increased involvement in the affairs of society, you will need to make a concerted effort to attract receptive souls from diverse groups, teaching them and confirming them in the faith. in this respect, the climate of search prevailing among both the leaders and the masses in your countries, which has emerged following the ideological upheaval of recent years, is of special significance. Two sectors have been particularly and differently affected and are athirst for the life-giving waters of bahá'u'lláh's revelation: on the one hand, the teachers in the national school systems and, on the other, university students and their professors. historically, both have exerted widespread influence in your societies, and should you teach them systematically, you will certainly reap abundant fruits.

in all of this great endeavor—pursuing large-scale expansion and consolidation, furthering the work of external affairs and carrying out activities of social and economic development—you must be driven by a passion to teach the faith. let regular study of the writings feed the flame of your enthusiasm. let his words so shape your thoughts that the most pressing obligation of your lives becomes the sharing of his message with others. 217 .6

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m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

98The designation given to the latin American communities by the guardian as the associates of the chief executors of the divine plan has defined for you a vast arena of service. As you take up the tasks of the four year plan,

keep in mind the words of the guardian calling on the individual believer to "... shed, heroically and irrevocably, the trivial and superfluous attachments which hold him back, empty himself of every thought that may tend to obstruct his path, mix, in obedience to the counsels of the Author of his faith, and in imitation of the one who is its true exemplar, with men and women, in all walks of life, seek to touch their hearts, through the distinction which characterizes his thoughts, his words and his acts, and win them over tactfully, lovingly, prayerfully and persistently, to the faith he himself has espoused."217-2

we shall remember each and all of you in our prayers in the holy Shrines and shall beseech bahá'u'lláh to vouchsafe to you his unfailing protection and guidance, as you boldly go forth to conquer the hearts of men.

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Supplementary Message—Riḍván Message 1996—

Indian Subcontinent and Region

Riḍván 153

To the followers of bahá'u'lláh in the Andaman and Nicobar islands, bangladesh, india, Nepal and Sri lanka

dearly loved friends,

with bright hopes and high expectations, we turn our thoughts towards you, who, serving in a region at the forefront of large-scale expansion, find yourselves poised to make a significant advance in the process of entry by troops, the central aim of the four year plan. your region, which claims a substantial percentage of the world's people, has a bahá'í population that already exceeds by far that of any other area of the globe.

by virtue of its immense natural and human resources, its magnificent history and the rich cultural diversity of its inhabitants, india plays a promi-

217-2. cc 2:1336.217.9

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99nent role in the shaping of human affairs. Throughout the history of the faith, it has been the recipient of countless blessings and the arena of un-

paralleled triumphs. mentioned by the báb in the first of his writings, india is eternally honored to have had one of its native sons numbered among the letters of the living, privileged to behold the first rays of the dawn of a New day. bahá'u'lláh himself selected and dispatched emissaries to propagate his faith in india, and, under the direction of 'Abdu'l-bahá and Shoghi effendi, streams of teachers from both iran and the west continued to flow to that land to help the believers carry forward the standard of divine guidance.

in response to the bountiful favors conferred upon them over the decades, the friends in india have made sacrificial efforts for the progress of the cause of bahá'u'lláh and have achieved splendid victories in his Name. They first demonstrated their ability to initiate entry by troops as early as the closing years of the Ten year crusade when they enlisted thousands of receptive souls into the ranks of his followers. The sudden influx of new adherents to the cause from all castes and creeds—clear evidence of the receptivity of that great nation—transformed a small body of believers into a vibrant and broadly based community which gradually learned to shoulder immense and inescapable responsibilities. its valiant members, relying on the un-
failing grace of bahá'u'lláh, surmounted the obstacles before them, persevered, and sustained their efforts until india came to occupy a privileged place in the eyes of the bahá'ís of the world.

The indian bahá'í community has gone from strength to strength. it has established the institutions of the faith throughout the length and breadth of that vast country, including suitable agencies to administer the affairs of the cause in each state; has undertaken countless projects and campaigns of expansion and consolidation; has produced and disseminated literature in a wide array of languages; has pursued numerous projects of social and economic development, especially in the field of education; and, aided by the power of attraction of its house of worship, has proclaimed the faith to many millions of people. from every standpoint—its administrative structure, its relations with the government, its experience in large-scale expansion, and the devotion of the active supporters of its programs and projects—the indian community stands in an enviable position at the beginning of this, the four year plan.

The bahá'í community of bangladesh, flourishing in the midst of a muslim society, is a source of joy to the entire bahá'í world. in recent years and 218.3

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m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

500with astonishing rapidity, that community began to achieve extraordinary

success in the teaching field, and throughout the Three year plan it has sus-

tained consistently large-scale expansion. its institutions have demonstrated

their capacity to mobilize the human resources at their disposal, and those who have responded to the call for action have sacrificially and with the utmost devotion spread the divine Teachings among the muslim, hindu

and tribal populations of that country. The purity of their motives and the sincerity of their efforts to address the needs of society have won them recognition from government officials in the highest circles. Their exertions to promote love and unity among the majority muslim and minority hindu

populations are bearing increasing fruit, a striking testimony to the potency of bahá'u'lláh's revelation.

in the himalayan kingdom of Nepal, the believers have, through the

integrity of their character and the excellence of their conduct, overcome in recent years restrictions on the expansion of the cause. They are now

held in high regard and are successfully engaged in presenting the faith to

the people as a unifying force which can contribute to the progress of the

nation. As they grow in strength, they can begin to look beyond their own

borders and assist in the propagation of the faith in those areas to which

they have such easy access.

in the indian ocean, the bahá'í community of Sri lanka, a nation with a

predominantly buddhist population, is addressing diligently the challenges

of growth. in spite of a number of setbacks in the past, the friends have

persevered and are using the power of their hard-won unity to respond to

the needs of that sorely tried country, whose suffering people thirst for the

vivifying waters of bahá'u'lláh's revelation. farther to the east, the bahá'í

community of the Andaman and Nicobar islands has steadily grown over

the years and is blessed with sincere and devoted believers, whose efforts

won them the distinction of having their own National Spiritual Assembly.

dear friends, the receptivity of your peoples and the extraordinary ad-

vances you have already made enable you to approach the challenges of

entry by troops with vigor and optimism, and to give systematic attention

to the tasks that must be diligently carried out to ensure accelerated growth.

your past exploits were largely the result of the incessant labors of a com-

paratively few consecrated believers who devoted their time and resources to the spread of the cause in locality after locality. if you are to sustain

rapid expansion and consolidation in the coming years, it is imperative that

far greater numbers of dedicated and committed souls arise to promote 218.6

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501these twin processes. T raining courses—widespread, regular and well-

organized—constitute the most effective means to mobilize believers on

the scale required. depending on the conditions of your countries, such

courses will be conducted by teachers associated with national, state or re-

gional institutes, some of which may well have several branches. Although the programs of the institutes may vary according to the characteristics

of the populations they serve, their essential functions will be the same.

They should seek to develop in the participants a good understanding of bahá'u'lláh's essential Teachings and to help them acquire those skills and

abilities that will enable them to serve the faith effectively. They should also

strive to imbue their hearts with a deep love for bahá'u'lláh—a love from

which stems a desire to submit oneself to his will, to obey his laws, to

heed h is exhortations and to promote h is faith.

while all the participants in these courses will naturally be directed to the

field of teaching, a sufficient number will also have to acquire the ability to assist with the development of local communities. in a region of the world

where villages constitute a major component of every nation, a concerted

effort must be made to establish in them the patterns of bahá'í community

life on a firm basis. This can only be achieved through perseverance and

constancy in working with the local communities. The friends in each local-ity must be helped to raise their awareness of the efficacy of the Teachings

they have accepted and to broaden their vision of the tasks and opportuni-

ties before them. The local Spiritual Assembly must be helped to take up

the challenges of community development and of expansion.

in this respect, we call upon you to give special attention to the advance-

ment of women. in almost all of your region, women have traditionally played a secondary role in the life of society, a condition which is still reflected in many bahá'í communities. effective measures have to be adopted to help women take their rightful place in the teaching and administrative fields. by teaching entire families, you can ensure that increasing numbers of women enter the faith, thereby improving the balance in the composition of your communities and beginning in each family, from the moment of acceptance, a process through which the fundamental principle of the equality between men and women can be realized.

of course, your successes in the teaching field and in the development of local communities will only yield lasting results if you ensure the proper education of children and youth. youth will undoubtedly be the most enthusiastic supporters of the programs of your institutes. They are eager to make

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502a significant contribution to the progress of their communities and have shown, time and again, their capacity to respond to the call to service. They can be trained to help shoulder the manifold responsibilities demanded by rapid expansion and consolidation. but it is especially important for large numbers of them to become capable teachers of bahá'í children's classes. As you are well aware, without the education of children it is impossible to maintain victories from one generation to the next.

All these tasks will require your concentrated attention. it is important, too, that you maintain the momentum which the activities of social and economic development have gained, especially in india. within their own sphere of competence, the specialized institutes, the schools and other projects are each engaged in work critical to the development of human resources. we hope that those who benefit from such programs will generously offer their talents to the institutions of the faith in furthering the interests of the four year plan.

As you respond to the requirements of the plans soon to be formulated by your institutions, you must ever bear in mind that you will contribute to the central aim of the four year plan only if you teach persistently, prayerfully, lovingly and wisely. you should endeavor to bring into your ranks

individuals from every stratum of society as you vigorously advance in the process of entry by troops. receptive souls should be sought among the affluent and the indigent, in the various circles of urban society and in schools and universities, in centers of industry and commerce and in the vast rural areas of your countries. you should also remember that your exertions are not to be limited to your own home fronts, but that from among you must continue to arise an increasing number of souls to serve as pioneers and traveling teachers in the international field.

in the coming years, enormous spiritual forces will be acting upon your peoples. you should be confident that your exertions will have a powerful effect on the course of their destinies. let the words of the guardian written during the first of the systematic plans to be launched in your region guide your endeavors: “ you should at all times fix your gaze on the promise of bahá’u’lláh, put your whole trust in his creative word, recall the past and manifold evidences of his all-encompassing and resistless power and arise to become worthy and exemplary recipients of his all-sustaining grace and blessings.”

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218-1. miS, p. 203.218.13

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50may the confirmations of the blessed beauty be ceaselessly showered upon you, and his All-p owerful Spirit inspire and sustain you throughout the collective enterprise on which you now embark.

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Supplementary Message—Riḍván Message 1996—

Southeast Asia

Riḍván 153

To the followers of bahá’u’lláh in cambodia, hong kong, lao people’s democratic republic, macau, malaysia, mongolia, myanmar, Singapore, Taiwan, Thailand, and v ietnam
dearly loved f riends,

Some four decades ago, in a message to the first regional convention of the bahá’ís of Southeast Asia, the guardian wrote of the “far-reaching

influence” that area would exercise on the “future destinies of the world bahá’í community.” he referred to the area’s “heterogeneous character” and

“geographical position,” underscored “the spiritual receptivity of many of its inhabitants,” and drew attention to “the role they are destined to play in

the future shaping of the affairs of mankind.” The remarkable progress of the faith in Southeast Asia since that time, in a period of social and political upheaval, is but a prelude to the fulfillment of the guardian’s promise.

This, taken together with the recent accomplishments of the believers in the neighboring territories as far north as Mongolia, gives rise to a brilliant

vision of future triumphs in the entirety of that vast region.

you now embark on the next stage of your endeavors, a four year plan

whose aim is to effect a significant advance in the process of entry by troops. Among your peoples, the majority of whom have been influenced by noble and high-minded teachings of Buddhism, are many who possess a profound

sense of spirituality, which is reflected in the practices of their daily lives

and in the quality of their relationships with one another, with nature, and

with their social institutions. They have a keen understanding of the need for coherence between the material and the spiritual, and are disturbed by

the effects of gross materialism on their societies in recent years. your region

represents a vast reservoir of potential promoters of the cause waiting to be 218.16

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50tapped. The number and quality of the active supporters of the faith with which it is already blessed bespeak the richness of that reservoir.

Systematic training programs constitute the most potent instrument at your disposal for realizing the potential of that highly promising region to contribute significantly to the human resources of the faith. To this end, the establishment and strengthening of institutes will undoubtedly be a central component of the plans of all your countries. your participation in institute programs, through which you will deepen your knowledge of the faith, cultivate your inner spiritual lives and develop abilities of service, will enable you to intensify your individual and collective exertions in the teaching field and will result in a commensurate acceleration in the expansion of your communities. varying patterns of growth, of course, will evolve

according to the particular conditions in each country.

in malaysia, large numbers of believers from among the chinese, indian

and indigenous populations can be mobilized, and their energies directed towards the stimulation of activity at the local level. many of the local

communities are in a position to implement plans and projects under the

direction of their local Spiritual Assemblies, and they should be encour-

aged and aided in their efforts to do so. The capacity to achieve rapid and

simultaneous expansion and consolidation exists in malaysia, but needs to

be fully exercised. Such an undertaking must be complemented by concrete

measures to broaden the range of activities in areas such as the advancement

of women, the spread of literacy, and the promotion of moral education—areas in which the malaysian community already has an impressive record.

in addition to contributing to the progress of society, such activities will go

far in winning the admiration and respect of the enlightened in government circles and, beyond that, in drawing the attention of leaders of thought throughout the region to the Teachings of the Faith.

The bahá'í community of myanmar, which traces its roots back to the

time of bahá'u'lláh, has in recent years been able to pay increasing attention

to the expansion of the faith. The results have been encouraging indeed.

The large body of believers in myanmar, faithful to the covenant and with

hearts filled with love for bahá'u'lláh, who stand ready to serve his faith,

can be helped by the institute program now being established there to enter the field of teaching with confidence. The effects such an endeavor will

have, in a land so receptive to the divine message, are incalculable.

The friends in Thailand may draw courage from the success of their

efforts to help reestablish the bahá'í community of cambodia and resolve 219.3

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505to turn with the same vigor and determination to the tasks of expansion

and consolidation in their homeland. There they have proved themselves

capable of teaching among many strata of society and of bringing into their

ranks people of diverse cultural and educational backgrounds. Setting aside all hesitation, and with unity of thought and purpose, let them dedicate the coming four years to the

unflagging pursuit of a clearly defined course of action traced for them by their institutions.

in vietnam, laos and cambodia, where possibilities for growth exist in varying degrees, the sorely tried, steadfast and devoted friends need to demonstrate to the authorities and leaders of their countries that bahá'ís, obedient and loyal to their governments, desire but the prosperity of their nations and the upliftment of their peoples. Through the spiritual enrichment of families in vietnam, through the program of deepening in small groups now initiated in laos, and through systematic plans for expansion and consolidation and for social and economic development in cambodia, where the friends enjoy greater freedom, each of these communities can achieve substantial progress within the parameters defined for them by prevailing social and political conditions.

The manner in which the bahá'í community of mongolia, so young and so full of vitality, has taken its affairs in hand is exhilarating. in the span of seven years, the friends have ranged methodically across that vast land and have established the faith on solid and enduring foundations. At the national level, they are becoming known for their high ideals, particularly as champions of the rights of children. At the same time, their bahá'í classes, open to children from bahá'í and non-bahá'í families alike, are being received with great enthusiasm, presenting them with extensive teaching opportunities. There is a spirit in the mongolian people which must needs manifest itself in the efflorescence of a numerically strong, vibrant community.

The bahá'í community of Singapore is energetic and dedicated. its past experience demonstrates that focused attention on expansion invariably brings good results. what is required at this stage of the community's development is an accelerating increase in the number of individual enrollments. Such an influx of new souls will continually strengthen the community which, although comparatively small, has demonstrated its ability to play an important role in the affairs of the faith in the region.

dear friends, any attempt to present, no matter how briefly, an overview of the potentialities of your region must necessarily take into account the preponderating influence that the chinese people are to exert on the des-219.7

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506 tiny of humankind. To them, ‘Abdu’l-b ahá has referred as “truth-seeking” and “prompted with ideal motives.” from among them, he declared, can be raised “such divine personages that each one of them may become the bright candle of the world of humanity.” The progress of the faith in hong kong, macau and Taiwan, and the labors of the chinese believers resident in other parts of the region, are early indications of that which is yet to come. we turn our expectant eyes towards the chinese people, confident in their ability to become illumined with the light of bahá’u’lláh’s revelation and to apply his Teachings, with characteristic diligence, to the advancement of spiritual and material civilization. As larger and larger numbers become imbued with heavenly qualities, and as they make sincere exertions for the progress of their people, they shall, god willing, win the trust of fair-minded leaders and be able to broaden the scope of their endeavors in a land that ‘Abdu’l-b ahá has designated “the country of the future.” we shall pray ardently at the Sacred Threshold that the blessings of bahá’u’lláh may sustain you and guide you in your noble services to his cause.

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Supplementary Message—Ridván Message 1996—

North America

Ridván 153

To the followers of bahá’u’lláh in North America: Alaska, canada, greenland and the u nited States
dearly loved f riends,

As members of the North American bahá’í community, you enter the four year plan with a brilliant record of progress in fulfilling the mandate issued by ‘Abdu’l-b ahá in the Tablets of the divine plan. in the eight decades since you received this mandate, your prodigious exertions have carried the message of bahá’u’lláh to all parts of your continent, and throughout the length and breadth of the planet. you have played a critical role in the establishment of the framework of the Administrative order and in the sustained proclamation of the faith. These Tablets launched you on a worldwide enterprise which you, and the generations to succeed you, are called upon to continue during the vast period of time stretching through-

out the formative Age and into the golden Age of the bahá'í dispensation.^{219.11}

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507in your pursuit of the provisions of the four year plan on national, regional and local levels, in conformity with the detailed plans to be formulated in the weeks ahead, you should constantly bear in mind the one central aim of the plan: advancing the process of entry by troops. There can be no doubt that this process, propelled by mysterious spiritual forces beyond the ken of the skeptic, will in due course quicken the souls of a multitude from every background in North America and dramatically increase the numerical strength of your communities.

Training institutes and other centers of learning are an indispensable element of a sustained endeavor to advance this process, and to ensure that the essential deepening of new believers is not neglected, that they develop the necessary skills to effectively teach the faith, and that an opportunity is provided for all bahá'ís, new and veteran, to embark on a systematic study of the fundamental verities of the revelation of bahá'u'lláh. we look to your communities to make an energetic response to the call for such institutes, and to develop a wide variety of approaches fitted to the needs of the diverse components of your population. in one of the Tablets of the divine plan, 'Abdu'l-bahá, exhorting the North American believers to strive to attain the exalted station of Apostles of bahá'u'lláh, specifies firmness in the covenant to be a prerequisite for this achievement.

220-1 we urge you to manifest unwavering adherence to the provisions of the covenant, while ever striving for a deeper understanding of its challenging features and of its implications, which far transcend the familiar arrangements of present society. you are in a most enviable position to provide a mighty impetus to the teaching work. Through the alertness and perseverance of your institutions and the effect of your exertions, there is now a general awareness of, and respect for, the cause in your region, and the faith has acquired a reputation for universality and liberality of thought. well may you rejoice at this remarkable achievement, and well may you contemplate the present needs of the cause with eagerness and confidence.

your accomplishments have prepared the way for even more spectacular

successes in the years immediately ahead. Now as never before should you strive mightily to free yourselves from the obstacles of apathy, attachment

to worldly pursuits, and lethargy, which stand in the way of so glorious a realization. As the people around you yearn increasingly for a society in which

220-1. See Tdp , no. 8.220.2

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508rectitude of conduct prevails, which is animated by a nobility of moral be -

havior, and in which the diverse races are firmly united, your challenge is to

demonstrate the efficacy of the message of bahá'u'lláh in ministering to their needs and in recreating the very foundation of individual and social life. The

whole of North America stands in desperate need of the inspiring vision, the dynamic sense of purpose and the idealism, which can be provided only by

those who are imbued with the spirit and truths of the bahá'í writings.

The community of the greatest Name must increasingly become re-

nowned for its social cohesion, and for the spirit of trust and confidence

which distinguishes the relationship between believers and their institu-

tions. in the earliest years of his ministry, the guardian stated, “. . . i hope

to see the friends at all times, in every land, and of every shade of thought

and character, voluntarily and joyously rallying round their local and in

particular their national centers of activity, upholding and promoting their

interests with complete unanimity and contentment, with perfect under-standing, genuine enthusiasm, and sustained vigor. This indeed is the one joy and yearning of my life, for it is the fountainhead from which all future

blessings will flow, the broad foundation upon which the security of the

divine edifice must ultimately rest.”

220-2 realization of this longing requires

that you commit yourselves to the wholehearted support of your institu-

tions. in turn, those of you called upon to serve as members of such bodies

should ever be mindful of the attitude and manner prescribed for the con-

duct of their duties, and should strive continually to approach the exalted standard set out in the Teachings.

in the divine plan bequeathed to you by ‘Abdu’l-bahá is disclosed the glorious destiny of those who are the descendants of the early inhabitants of your continent. we call upon the indigenous believers who are firmly rooted in the bahá’í Teachings to aid, through both deed and word, those who have not yet attained that level of understanding. progress along the path to their destiny requires that they refuse to be drawn into the divisiveness and militancy around them, and that they strive to make their own distinctive contribution to the pursuit of the goals of the four year plan, both beyond the confines of North America and at home. They should be ever mindful of the vital contribution they can make to the work of the faith throughout the American continent, in the circumpolar areas and in the Asian region of the Russian Federation.

220-2. bA, p. 66.220.7

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509we direct the attention of the believers of African descent, so beloved by the master, to the pressing need for pioneers, who will contribute to the further development of the cause in distant areas, including the continent of Africa for which they were assigned a special responsibility by the guardian when the first systematic campaign was launched for its spiritual illumination. Although their contributions to all aspects of bahá’í service on the home front and elsewhere will be of great value, they can be a unique source of encouragement and inspiration to their African brothers and sisters who are now poised on the threshold of great advances for the faith of bahá’u’lláh.

increasingly over the years, the bahá’í community in North America has been augmented by the addition of a substantial number of believers who have come from the cradle of the faith. we urge all the friends of persian background, who constitute a most valuable source of ability and experience, to dedicate themselves, to an extent surpassing their past services, to the accomplishment of the goals of the four year plan, under the leadership and guidance of the institutions of the faith in North America. The unity of thought and endeavor between the friends from east and west will offer a shining example of the power of bahá’u’lláh to demolish traditional barriers

and will be a powerful source of attraction to the cause.

The Alaskan bahá'ís are privileged to live in an area described by the guardian as “a region destined to play an important role in shaping the spiritual destinies of the great republic of the west of which it forms a part, and to contribute, in no small measure, to the establishment of the institutions of his world order throughout the American continent.”

220-3 The

invaluable contribution they have made to the establishment of the faith in Siberia in recent years, together with their significant advances in strengthening the home front, provide compelling evidence of their capacity to take full advantage of the opportunities before them in the four year plan.

The valiant canadian bahá'í community was praised by the guardian for

“the staunchness of the faith of its members, their unyielding resolve, their ceaseless efforts, their willingness to sacrifice, their exemplary loyalty, their steadfast courage,”

220-4 a description fully confirmed by the record of its

achievements during the Three year plan. it has played a disproportionately

220-3. he, p. 36.

220-4. mc, p. 60.220.9

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510 great and much-appreciated role in the defense of the faith, in its propagation to all corners of the earth, and in the establishment of its institutions in other lands, both near and far, and is in an enviable position to build upon these successes in the new plan on which it now embarks.

our thoughts turn often to the bahá'í community of greenland, whose staunchness of faith and dogged perseverance have won our admiration and praise, and have resulted in the faith's becoming firmly established in that distant land. inspired by the promise set out in the Tablets of the divine plan that “if the hearts be touched with the heat of the love of god, that

territory will become a divine rose-garden and a heavenly paradise, and the souls, even as fruitful trees, will acquire the utmost freshness and beauty,”

220-5 let them now go forth to claim new victories on the home front and to transform their nation through the power of the divine Teachings.

Some four decades ago, Shoghi effendi described the members of the united States bahá'í community as "the outstanding protagonists of the cause of god; the stout-hearted defenders of its integrity, its claims and its rights; the champion-builders of its Administrative order; the standard-bearers of its crusading hosts; the torchbearers of its embryonic civilization; the chief succorers of the downtrodden, the needy and the fettered among its followers. . . ."

220-6 Any survey of the distinguished accomplishments

of these dearly loved friends during the past three years provides striking evidence of the continuing applicability of this description, and of the immense contribution they are making to the advancement of the cause.

we look to the members of the bahá'í community in the united States to perform, during the four year plan, heroic deeds of service to the cause, which will astonish and inspire their fellow-believers throughout the world.

in North America, there are opportunities for the advancement of the process of entry by troops, the like of which presently exist in no other place on earth. Three unique characteristics combine to give rise to this condition:

the unparalleled strength of your local communities, particularly evident in the activity of your local Spiritual Assemblies and in the consecration of the bahá'í youth; the positive impression of the faith which has been

conveyed, not only to the generality of the population, but also to leaders of thought and people of influence; and the composition of your nations,

220-5. Tdp , no. 5.2.

220-6. cf , pp. 141–42.220.13

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511which have welcomed to their shores immigrants, students and refugees from all parts of the planet, drawn from all the major racial, ethnic and religious backgrounds of humanity. you, who live in a continent described by 'Abdu'l-b ahá as "the land wherein the splendors of his light shall be revealed, where the mysteries of his faith shall be unveiled, the home of the righteous, and the gathering-place of the free,"220-7 are called upon to take

full advantage of these favorable circumstances.

dear friends, now must you commit yourselves to the work of the cause afresh, liberated from any doubts, uncertainties or hesitations which may have impeded you in the past. every stratum of society must be brought

within your embrace, as you vigorously advance toward the goal of entry by troops at this time when powerful spiritual forces are at work in the hearts of the people. Neither the affluent nor the indigent should be excluded from your purview. receptive souls should be sought in the sophisticated circles

of urban society, on the campuses of colleges and universities, in centers of industry and commerce, on the farms and villages of the mountains, plains and prairies—wherever are to be found human beings in search of

the divine T ruth. you should strive to create a bahá'í community which will offer to the entire world a vibrant model of unity in diversity. The influence

of your exertions can extend well beyond the confines of North America; in particular, french canadian believers can perform an invaluable service to

the faith in the french-speaking nations and islands throughout the world,

the bahá'ís dwelling in the Arctic and subarctic regions can powerfully reinforce the work of the cause in the circumpolar areas, and the friends

of hispanic background have fertile fields before them throughout latin

America. let all believers consider the extent to which they can use familial

and ethnic ties to other regions of the world for the fulfillment of the global mission conferred on the recipients of the Tablets of the d ivine p lan.

At this critical hour in the fortunes of humanity, our eyes turn with

eagerness and hope to the bahá'ís of all parts of North America, who con-

stitute a reservoir of human and material resources unmatched elsewhere in the bahá'í world. As you proceed along your prescribed path, you should be

ever mindful of these words addressed to you by the Author of the Tablets of the divine plan: “i fervently hope that in the near future the whole earth

may be stirred and shaken by the results of your achievements. The hope

220-7 . Tdp , no. 9.3.220.16

220.17

m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

512which ‘Abdu’l-b ahá cherishes for you is that the same success which has at-

tended your efforts in America may crown your endeavors in other parts of

the world, that through you the fame of the cause of god may be diffused

throughout the east and the west, and the advent of the kingdom of the

lord of hosts be proclaimed in all the five continents of the globe.”220-8
our ardent prayers at the Sacred Threshold will surround and accom-
pany you at every step of the momentous undertaking to which you are now summoned.

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Supplementary Message—Ridván Message 1996—

Europe

Ridván 153

To the followers of Bahá'u'lláh in Europe

dearly loved friends,

forty-three years ago, when the European Bahá'ís gathered at the confer-
ence in Stockholm called by the beloved guardian for the launching of the
mighty Ten Year Crusade in your continent, you had but three National
Spiritual Assemblies—those of the British Isles, of Germany and Austria,
and of Italy and Switzerland—together with slowly developing local com-
munities in the other countries of Western Europe. In the East, cut off by
political barriers, were tiny remnants of communities which had been raised

up in earlier years and, in neighboring Turkey, was a small, struggling national
community. As the European believers of that time contemplated

the awe-inspiring tasks before them, they heard the words of the Guardian,

illuminating the historical significance of the continent in which they were to build the
institutions of Bahá'u'lláh's embryonic world order:

A continent, occupying such a central and strategic position on the

entire planet; so rich and eventful in its history, so diversified in its culture; from whose soil
sprang both the Hellenic and Roman civi-

lizations; the mainspring of a civilization to some of whose features Bahá'u'lláh himself paid
tribute; on whose southern shores Chris-

220-8. Tdp, no. 7.4.220.18

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51tendom first established its home; along whose eastern marches the
mighty forces of the cross and the crescent so frequently clashed; on
whose southwestern extremity a fast-evolving Islamic culture yielded
its fairest fruit; in whose heart the light of the reformation shone so

brightly, shedding its rays as far as the outlying regions of the globe. . . .

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This, your continent, whose soil was blessed by the footsteps of bahá'u'lláh himself, which was twice visited by 'Abdu'l-bahá in his epoch-making journeys following his release from imprisonment, whose travelers and scholars early responded to the dawning light of the bábí revelation, two of whose governments extended the hand of succor during the heroic Age of the faith, and whose nations, in recent years, have intervened so effectively in defense of the persecuted bahá'ís in iran, has amply demonstrated the capacity of its people to rally to the banner of the cause of god, once their hearts are touched and their minds awakened to its message. in the course of these forty-three years the european bahá'í communities have shown great vitality. The number of National Spiritual Assemblies has risen to thirty-four, covering the entire continent and embracing, in the case of russia, vast territories as far as the pacific ocean. great victories have been won for the faith by european pioneers in Africa, the pacific, the caribbean region and greenland. your institutions have distinguished themselves in external affairs. your communities include outstanding scholars of the faith, musicians, artists, scientists and those concerned with the application of bahá'í Teachings to economics and business. you have exerted special efforts for the advancement of women and the strengthening of family life. The european bahá'í youth council provides a focal point and a source of stimulation to the youth in all parts of europe, complemented by a network of National and local youth committees closely linked to and supported by their National and local Spiritual Assemblies. Now is the time to build on these achievements, clearly focusing all efforts on the central purpose of taking the message of bahá'u'lláh to a spiritually famished population.

The first task of your National Spiritual Assemblies immediately after rixvân will be to formulate, in consultation with the counselors, the details

221-1. ud, p. 319.221.2

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m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

51 of the four year plan, country by country. The participation of the local Spiritual Assemblies and individual believers in evolving their own local plans, and in following the lines of action to be clearly laid down, will be essential for the successful achievement of the high aims of this stage of the implementation of the divine plan of 'Abdu'l-bahá.

Europe is a continent of great variety, and each of your National Assemblies will be studying with care the processes and achievements required for the advancement of the cause of God in its area during the coming four years. Each must consider the current condition of its community, the territory within which it is working, and areas of potential collaboration with other Bahá'í communities. Special attention will need to be paid to the attainment of official recognition in those countries where the institutions of the faith are not yet legally incorporated, and to raising up National Spiritual Assemblies in certain of those independent countries and major islands, such as the Faroes, which have not yet attained them. There are, however, certain elements of an even wider vision which must be considered as they apply to specific countries, groups of countries and the entire continent.

There are areas which cry out for pioneers and traveling teachers; the mind turns, for example, to the work among the Sami and the other peoples of the Arctic and subarctic areas as far north as Spitsbergen. We contemplate the significance of teaching the faith in the islands of the Mediterranean, the Atlantic and the North Sea; the continent-wide importance of the Romany peoples, who have begun to show such receptivity to the call of Bahá'u'lláh; the opportunity for the European Bahá'í communities to demonstrate the salutary nature of the Teachings in relation to minorities of every kind; the specific tasks described by the beloved Guardian as the destiny of certain communities, and their responsibilities in far-flung lands where their languages are spoken; the implications of the advancement of the faith in Italy where is to be found "the heart and stronghold of the leading, the most ancient and powerful church of Christendom"; the need to rapidly increase the number of Bahá'í centers in the vast areas of the Ukraine and European Russia; and, beyond this, the special responsibilities and opportunities of the Bahá'í community of the Russian Federation, the larger part of whose area lies in Asia and must continue to benefit from collaboration with neighboring communities of central, southern and eastern Asia as well as Alaska, Canada and the United States. All these are but some

examples of the challenges which you face in the years ahead.221.5

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515The central aim of the four year plan, a significant advance in the process of entry by troops, is of especial significance for Europe. You should have no misgivings—it is a process that can advance in all parts of Europe, in the west as well as in the east. All should recognize that entry by troops is an inevitable stage in the development of the cause. The nature of the process is clarified in the compilation on the subject,221-2 whence it becomes apparent that the desired outcome, a sustained entry by troops, cannot be achieved by a mere series of spasmodic, uncoordinated exertions, no matter how enthusiastic. Confidence; unity of vision; systematic, realistic, but audacious planning; acceptance of the fact that mistakes will be made, and willingness to learn from these mistakes; and, above all, reliance on the guidance and sustaining confirmations of Bahá'u'lláh will advance this process.

The establishment of training institutes in various locations is emphasized in the four year plan because current methods, valuable though they are, are not adequate by themselves to meet the challenges of this new stage in the growth of the cause. The character and structure of the training institutes must be adapted to the conditions of each country and region; clearly their form in Europe will not be identical with that of training institutes in the rural areas of India. Their essential functions, however, will be the same. They will foster a firm acceptance of Bahá'í identity in those who take part: the capacity to look upon the world and its conditions from the point of view of the Teachings rather than from the standpoint of one's nationality or non-Bahá'í background. They will help to develop in each participant a deep love for Bahá'u'lláh, a good understanding of his essential Teachings and an awareness of the importance of developing the spiritual life of each individual through prayer, meditation and immersion in the Sacred writings. They will also cover such practical matters as how to teach the faith, for there are too many who, for lack of confidence in their ability to do so, are hesitant to convey the message. The transformation that such deepening in the faith produces will surely inflame the hearts of the individual friends with the longing to share this message with those around them, and this

is the seed of all success in teaching. Those who have attended training institutes will be able to help the other bahá'ís, new and old, to increase

221-2. See cc 3, pp. 154–203.221.7

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m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

516their potential for teaching, and so to greatly increase the human resources

of the cause, in which every believer is a teacher.

The teaching of the faith by the friends in europe must increase in

range; it must be varied, spontaneous and individual on the one hand, and focused, united and mutually supportive on the other. it must be both in-

spiring and practical and must, above all, be informed with serene faith in

the power of bahá'u'lláh. you should widen the field of your teaching work

to include the country people and the masses laboring in the cities; people

of little education as well as intellectuals in university towns. you should

consciously approach every stratum of society, adapting your methods,

literature and audiovisual materials to each audience. both the heart and

the mind need to be fed; both spiritual force and intellectual clarity must

be recognized as vital elements of the teaching work. you have excelled in

the use of the arts for the proclamation, expansion and consolidation of the faith; this is a key to opening many doors and should be encouraged and

developed. your unity, enthusiasm, confidence and perseverance, strength-

ened and guided by the power of prayer, cannot fail to act as a channel for

divine confirmations, which will be a magnet to seeking souls.

for our part, we shall pray ardently at the Sacred Threshold that you,

who have won such historic victories in your homelands and throughout

the world, will enter during the four year plan into a stage of even greater

achievement, presaging the as yet unimaginable glories destined to unfold during the twenty-first century.

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Supplementary Message—Ridván Message 1996—

Africa

Ridván 153

To the f ollowers of b ahá'u'lláh in Africa

dearly loved f riends,

you come to the four year plan with an extraordinary history of achieve-

ment, which indicates that you are well equipped spiritually and adminis-tratively, and in the inherent potential of your people, to respond success-fully to the plan's central aim to advance the process of entry by troops.

in whatever direction south of the Sahara one may look—whether to the 221.9

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1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

517eastern, western, central or southern region of the continent—portents of great, imminent expansion are evident. The torch of faith burns brightly in your hearts, setting our spirits aglow with gladness at the scale of your attainments and the magnificent possibilities that are now yours.

The bright hope inspired by such observations is justified by thrilling facts. The spiritual endowments of Africa derive naturally from the creative forces universally released by the revelation of bahá'u'lláh, but these have been marvelously enhanced by the continent's direct associations with the channels of such forces: the ship transporting the blessed beauty on his exile to the holy land touched briefly its northern shores; the center of the covenant spent extended periods in egypt before and after his historic visit to the west. The continent was also twice crossed from south to north by the beloved guardian. bahá'u'lláh favored the black peoples by making a specific reference to them when, as the master testified, he compared them to the "black pupil of the eye" through which "the light of the spirit shineth forth."

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African bahá'í history had its beginnings in egypt, which was opened to the faith during the period of the ministry of bahá'u'lláh; it gathered momentum during the ministry of 'Abdu'l-b ahá when bahá'í localities were established in South Africa and T unisia. but the early effects of these spiritual endowments became more obvious with the remarkable success of the two-year Africa project (1951–53) when 16 territories were opened, bringing to 25 the total number of countries and islands in which bahá'ís resided; this preceded the opening of the 33 virgin territories called for in the beloved guardian's Ten year global crusade, a period of astonishing development in Africa that evoked the admiration and praise of Shoghi

effendi as many people from different tribes entered the cause, a number of administrative institutions were formed, and it became possible to raise up the mother Temple of Africa in the heart of the continent. during the course of these rapid developments, the African believers themselves, through sacrificial effort as teachers and pioneers, arose to champion the cause of god, manifesting the profundity of their response to the message of the New day.

in the countries lying to the north where programs of public teaching cannot now be pursued, the friends have continued for many years to maintain their posts with circumspection and heroic fortitude. Not only

222-1. Abl, p. 68.222.2

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m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

518have they kept the flame of faith alive in their hearts, they also endeavor to transmit the fire of the love of god to members of their families, including their children and youth, in anticipation of the day when freedom to openly proclaim their religion and conduct their community affairs is secured. with immense gratification we now look back over just a few decades during which Africa attained the largest number of National Spiritual Assemblies of any continent; moreover, Africa's local Spiritual Assemblies amount to a substantial percentage of the world's total. The prodigious output of energy devoted to expansion and consolidation has included major endeavors to train the believers and to mount and maintain development projects. As a result the African bahá'í community can boast of notable progress in the establishment of a number of primary and secondary schools and training institutes. A source of much of this energy in recent times has been the African youth, who have increasingly demonstrated exemplary dedication and vigor in their bahá'í activities. in the field of external affairs, the African community, whether in small or large states, has shown a boldness, a creativity, and a tenacity that have resonated in the worldwide proclamation of the faith and the promotion of its vital interests.

clearly, then, Africa is poised to register a victory for the cause that will reaffirm its position among the front ranks of our world community. The time is critical, and you must act promptly to realize this prospect. we

therefore urge our African brothers and sisters to take immediate account of their strengths, needs and opportunities, and then resolve to turn the challenge posed by these conditions into the means of success. you will

of necessity give concentrated attention to various plans and programs of activity if you are to advance to new stages of entry by troops, but simultaneously certain underlying requisites will claim your special vigilance and exertion. These are the elimination of tribal prejudice, the transformation

of prevailing social practices, and the fostering of education.

Tribal conflict is one of the most pressing issues facing Africa. This must be dealt with in the heart of every faithful follower of bahá'u'lláh and resolutely overcome through the collective will of every local and national bahá'í community. indeed, how can the lovers of the blessed beauty allow tribal prejudice and rivalry to be practiced in their midst when he has made unity the pivotal principle and goal of his faith? hatred and animosity based on tribe, like those based on race, blight the human spirit and arrest the development of the society that accommodates them. if outside the bahá'í community in recent years influential persons and public officials have been

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519able to see the practical benefit of bringing diverse groups together towards

unity, how much more should it be possible for those imbued with the spirit of our Teachings to strive to eliminate within the bahá'í fellowship

the unsavory characteristics of tribal division and disunity. it is imperative and urgent in the current state of society for the bahá'ís so to practice

genuine unity among themselves and in their relations to others that they may become renowned as a new people in the eyes of all Africans. Such a

demonstration will attract divine confirmations and greatly reinforce their power to succeed in spreading the Teachings.

much of what distinguishes African life is to be found in patterns of

behavior displayed in the tribe and particularly in the family. increasingly,

urban life threatens to destroy the positive qualities of such patterns. Since change is inevitable if progress is to be made by any African society, a prima-

ry challenge to bahá'ís is to preserve and improve those wholesome aspects

of tribal and family custom that are in accord with the bahá'í Teachings

and to dispense with those that are not. Such a challenge must be embraced

with the understanding that the book of god is the standard by which to weigh all forms of behavior. while unwavering action is necessary, wisdom and tact and patience must, of course, be exercised. let it be understood, too, that Africans are not alone in the struggle to change certain age-old practices. people everywhere have customs which must be abandoned so as to clear the path along which their societies must evolve towards that glorious, new civilization which is to be the fruit of bahá'u'lláh's stupendous revelation. indeed, in no society on earth can there be found practices which adequately mirror the standards of his cause. his own truth-bearing words clarify the matter: "The summons and the message which we gave were never intended to reach or to benefit one land or one people only. mankind in its entirety must firmly adhere to whatsoever hath been revealed and vouchsafed unto it. Then and only then will it attain unto true liberty. The whole earth is illuminated with the resplendent glory of god's revelation."

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The acute inadequacy of plans and programs to educate Africa's people poses a particular challenge to the followers of bahá'u'lláh in that continent, for he has emphasized the importance of education for all; and individuals ought to be taught at least to read and write. The education of which

222-2. Tb, p. 89.222.8

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520bahá'u'lláh spoke includes both spiritual and material aspects. The lack of such education affects the ability of people to achieve true progress. This matter should be of the keenest interest to all segments of the community.

parents have a special responsibility to see that their children, both boys and girls, receive an education; and they must take care that the girls are not left behind, since well-educated girls are a guarantee of the excellence of future

society; indeed, preference should, if necessary, be given to their education.

closely linked to this concern is the principle of the equality of men and women taught by bahá'u'lláh. it is also highly desirable for adults, both men

and women, who are illiterate to participate in literacy programs, so that gradually all bahá'ís will be able to read the word of god for themselves.

The bahá'í community is not fully equipped to undertake what responsible

authorities have neglected to do for the education of the people; however, the bahá'í institutions at all levels are urged to give attention to these critical needs, as circumstances permit.

bearing in mind these three foregoing considerations, you can move vigorously and wisely to tackle the manifold tasks implied by the plan's emphasis on advancing the process of entry by troops. An extension of your efforts to effect both expansion and consolidation on a wholly new scale is imperative. The one suggests a powerful outward thrust of your teaching activities to cover the length and breadth of your countries, reaching the remotest areas with the divine message. The other indicates a drive to consolidate and multiply your gains through an ever-deepening penetration of spiritual knowledge of the faith into the hearts of the believers, a systematic development of human resources, and a marked improvement in the functioning of your national and, particularly, your local institutions.

in all this exertion, the three components of the process—the individual, the institutions and the community—must assume their respective responsibilities. we especially expect you all to pursue every means at your disposal that will bring about the realization of an organic unity between the local Spiritual Assembly and the community, and thereby establish a sharp contrast to the fragmentation of present-day social life. Thus, we long to see the individual African believers arise in greater numbers to claim the faith of bahá'u'lláh as their own and to take on the requisite tasks of teaching and administering a rapidly expanding faith. And we look for accumulating evidence that the Spiritual Assemblies are taking to heart their god-given mandate and are conscientiously fulfilling their obligations to bahá'u'lláh to foster the growth and development of vibrant communities in which adults, 222.10 222.11

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521youth and children are more and more integrated and active. To fulfill these expectations is to demonstrate to a skeptical world the power of the faith to hold aloft a new standard for the guidance of the nations, and eventually to attract the disillusioned masses to the security of god's faith. what specific actions, you may well ask, would indicate that you are fulfilling the basic requirement of the plan in Africa? A reply would include mention of the following. whatever the state of expansion in a commu-

nity, take the next steps to increase enrollments, deepen the believers and strengthen the teaching force. where entry by troops is in progress, intensify your efforts to stimulate further increase in the number of believers, while at the same time conducting a program of training that will deepen the new believers and raise up new teachers on a continuing basis. maximize action to bring families into the faith by encouraging individuals in their duty to endeavor to lead as many of their family members as possible to the light of divine guidance. regularize efforts to teach among the sub-Saharan muslims. proliferate the publication of bahá'í literature and audiocassette tapes, especially in vernacular languages. Swell the number of local Spiritual Assemblies elected by their communities without help from outside. Support more abundantly the funds of the faith. orient believers from among the traditional rulers to the Teachings, so that they will find appropriate ways to serve the faith. moreover, extend provisions for children regularly to attend bahá'í classes for their spiritual training. give consistent attention to involving the youth in the expansion and consolidation work and to opening channels of activity suited to their talents and necessary for their development into mature bahá'ís. increase the number and effectiveness of observances of Nineteen day feasts. expand the use of music and drama in the proclamation and teaching work, an effort in which Africa has already distinguished itself. multiply plans and programs to raise the status of women and to encourage the active support of men in such endeavors. extend the range of your exertions in the fields of external affairs and social and economic development. you will readily appreciate, then, the emphasis placed on multiplying the number of training institutes; for without them it will be impossible to meet the needs of hugely expanding communities. in some places, the friends may find it possible to offer sites and facilities for these essential operations, which must be located in as many areas as necessary to provide regular and well-organized training to increasing numbers of believers. The programs of the institutes must be designed to instill in the participants a good under-

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522standing of the fundamental verities of the faith and to help them acquire

skills and abilities that will enable them to serve the faith effectively. immediately after *riḍván* your National Spiritual Assemblies will initiate efforts to formulate, in consultation with the counselors, the details of the four year plan, country by country. To ensure that the plan is broadly based and responsive to the needs of all areas of a country, the participation of the local Spiritual Assemblies and individuals, in evolving their own local plans and in following the lines of action to be clearly laid down, will be essential.

dear friends, we are acutely conscious of the crushing difficulties that afflict life in Africa: the conditions that have caused a flood of refugees on the continent, the horrors created by ethnic conflict, the political unrest, the economic distress, the high incidence of hunger and disease, the horrendous natural disasters. but, paradoxical as it may seem, there exist in all of these the very possibilities of your success. your ability to endure and forge ahead is reinforced in the assurance given by the divine physician, who anticipated all these conditions and prescribed a sure remedy. his prescriptions have been placed in your hands.

Therefore, we remind you of the noble ambitions the beloved guardian held for you as a people in a continent that has “a great contribution to make to the advancement of world civilization.” may such memories resound afresh in your hearts, quickening your will to fulfill the major aim of the plan before you, and setting a pace for your actions like the urgent rhythm of drums pulsating throughout your immensely potent, far-stretching land. our ardent prayer at the holy Threshold on your behalf is that the divine storehouses of heaven may pour out their bounties upon you all, healing your ills, magnifying your powers, and enabling you to achieve victory upon victory.

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Supplementary Message—*Riḍván* Message 1996—

Western and Central Asia

Riḍván 153

To the followers of bahá'u'lláh in western and central Asia

dearly loved friends,

As a turbulent yet luminous century draws to a close, the bahá'í community is embarking on another campaign in the progressive unfoldment of the divine plan. The global enterprises thus far executed by the consecrated adherents of his cause have systematically spread the light of bahá'u'lláh's revelation to every corner of the earth and have firmly established the institutions of his Administrative order. The four year plan, whose primary aim is to effect a significant advance in the process of entry by troops, is being launched at a time when the cause of god has emerged from obscurity, when its contributions to society are being increasingly acknowledged, and when humanity's prolonged and continuous suffering has created an atmosphere of search for spiritual values and has raised the level of receptivity to the cause.

we call upon our much-loved coworkers in the western and central parts

of the Asiatic continent, the home of the oldest and most venerable bahá'í

communities, to rally round their divinely ordained institutions and to arise during these years to demonstrate once again the devotion, valor and deter-

mination which have already conferred matchless distinction upon them. you have the honor of serving the faith in a region above whose horizon the

dawn of the great day of the lord appeared, in whose bosom the infant

cause of god was nurtured, on whose soil so much sacred blood was shed,

on whose western shores the qiblih of the people of bahá is established,

within whose embrace the first mashriqu'l-A dhkár was raised, and from

which hosts of devoted and committed bahá'ís have, in the past decades, set

out to bear the banner of the faith to every part of the globe.

our thoughts turn first to the community of bahá'u'lláh's lovers in the

land where his faith was born. Although they are still denied the freedom

to resume direct participation in the series of campaigns by which the cause

is steadily advancing throughout the world, their achievements constitute irrefutable proof of the creative power of the daily sacrifices they are making for the vindication of the faith. what is becoming apparent, as this

new global plan opens, is that the build-up of spiritual strength within the 223.1

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52 Iranian bahá'í community—purified by suffering and steeled by adversity—represents a reservoir of energy that will, in god's good time, bring incalculable benefits to the cause. "Say: The springs that sustain the life of these birds are not of this world. Their source is far above the reach and ken of human apprehension." 223-1

in the lands to the south and west of Iran, bahá'ís live under restrictions which prevent them from teaching the cause to their fellow-countrymen. yet, by the outstanding contributions they have made to the progress of the faith in other parts of the world, they have proved that their enthusiasm to spread the divine message cannot be dampened. it has been particularly heartening to witness the eagerness and rapidity with which, as soon as the barriers to teaching in the republics of central Asia and the caucasus were removed, they rushed to the aid of the small bands of believers who had persevered there for so many decades and helped them to build the vibrant communities now flourishing in these regions today. No doubt they will continue to lend valuable assistance to the communities in central Asia and the caucasus during the four year plan.

in these republics, through the combined efforts of native and visiting teachers, extraordinary advances can be expected. A pattern for the rapid growth of the cause has already been established in the region: locality after locality has been opened to the faith and, because of the high receptivity of the people, the number of believers in each place has quickly risen, resulting in the election of a Spiritual Assembly to guide the affairs of the nascent community. integral to this pattern, almost from the very outset, has been the holding of regular institute courses, which have assisted the friends in becoming strong promoters of the cause. if the expansion and consolidation activities are vigorously pursued according to this same pattern in the coming years, the growth of the faith will accelerate, greatly increasing the number of believers and centers.

To effect such accelerated growth, the friends in these countries must become so deepened in their understanding of the faith as to take up, on their own initiative, the torch of guidance that will enlighten the multitudes. They should not be content with small communities, nor allow the tasks of

administering their own community affairs to divert them from the essential purpose of bringing new members into their ranks. each community, from

223-1. gwb, no. 163.2.223.4

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525the earliest phases of its development, should be fired by a vision of the glory of the cause and imbued with the zeal to achieve rapid and sustained expansion both in the locality itself and in the nearby towns and villages.

in pakistan, where a well-grounded community traces its roots back

some hundred years, the friends must make a mighty effort to increase their numbers significantly among people of every walk of life. The will and de-

termination needed to sustain large-scale expansion and consolidation can

be created through a consistent and widespread institute program aimed at exposing growing contingents of believers to the creative word, thus

enhancing their spiritual capacities to diffuse the light of the faith and to

further the development of its institutions. Such a rapid process of growth requires that more and more women be enabled to move to the forefront of bahá'í activity, in both the teaching and administrative fields. while ris-

ing to the challenge of entry by troops in their homeland, the friends in pakistan need also to pay special attention to their long-suffering Afghan

neighbors, who cry out for the healing message of bahá'u'lláh, the one true balm for their afflictions.

in all your countries, you must continue to give the highest priority

to the education of children. having seen the effects of the Teachings of

bahá'u'lláh on generation after generation, you well understand the value

of bahá'í education and of a proper spiritual upbringing. in those areas

where activities are restricted, you are nevertheless able to teach the chil-dren of your own communities and help them to grow to become pillars of strength. in other areas, you have the possibility, nay the obligation, to open

your classes to children of non-b ahá'í families and to become known as the educators of the coming generations of your peoples.

dear friends, the time is short, and weighty responsibilities have been

placed on the shoulders of each and every bahá'í. in his most holy book,

the kitáb-i-Aqdas, the b lessed b eauty states:

verily, we behold you from our realm of glory, and will aid who-
soever will arise for the triumph of our cause with the hosts of the
concourse on high and a company of our favored angels.

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223-2. kA, ¶53.223.7

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526be confident that your dedicated services will, like a magnet, attract
the promised confirmations and that your hearts will be gladdened as you
witness the successive triumphs of the cause you hold so dear. we shall
remember all of you in our prayers in the holy Shrines and shall beseech
bahá'u'lláh to guide and assist you, as you face the many challenges of these
spiritually potent closing years of the century.

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Supplementary Message—Ridván Message 1996—

Pacific Region

Ridván 153

To the followers of bahá'u'lláh in Australia, the cook islands, the eastern
caroline islands, the fiji islands, french polynesia, the hawaiian islands,
indonesia, japan, kiribati, korea, the mariana islands, the marshall islands,
New caledonia and the loyalty islands, New zealand, papua New guinea,
the philippines, Samoa, the Solomon islands, Tonga, T uvalu, vanuatu, and
the w estern caroline i slands

dearly loved f riends,

you are privileged to live in a region of the world unique in the oppor-
tunities it offers to advance the interests of the faith during the course of
the four year plan. you constitute bahá'í communities within, or on the
fringe of, the vast pacific ocean, with which is associated this promise of
bahá'u'lláh: "Should they attempt to conceal his light on the continent, he
will assuredly rear his head in the midmost part of the ocean and, raising
his voice proclaim: 'i am the life-giver of the world.'"224-1 At a time when

the dear bahá'í friends in the cradle of the faith yearn for the yoke of oppression to be lifted from their shoulders, you can compensate for their present and temporary inability to propagate the faith if you undertake a sustained endeavor to convey the divine message to the peoples of your countries and multiply bahá'í institutions throughout these lands. within your region is to be found a vast diversity of races, cultures, languages and religious traditions, illustrative of the major influences which

224-1. wob, p. 78.223.10

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527have shaped the affairs of humanity throughout history. one of this region's distinguishing features is described by the guardian as "a spiritual axis, extending from the Antipodes to the northern islands of the pacific ocean—an axis whose northern and southern poles will act as powerful magnets, endowed with exceptional spiritual potency, and towards which other younger and less experienced communities will tend for some time to gravitate."224-2 This emphasizes the vital role to be played by the bahá'í communities of Northeastern Asia and of the Antipodes in the spiritual illumination of the surrounding areas.

every country of the region must witness, in the course of the four year plan, a significant advance in the process of entry by troops. it is essential that the plans formulated on national and local levels reflect this vital aim. The advancement of this process will require that greater attention be given not only to fostering individual initiative in the teaching work, but also to developing human resources through the establishment and efficient operation of training institutes and other centers of learning, and to vastly increasing the strength and quality of the functioning of the local Spiritual Assemblies.

we direct a special appeal to the indigenous believers in all parts of the pacific region, men and women alike, to intensify their efforts to acquire a deeper understanding of the revelation of bahá'u'lláh, and to strive for a position in the forefront of the promoters of the faith through their teaching endeavors on the home front and their international cooperation in programs of the ocean of light. As the tensions and divisions of a declining

social order increase, the believers throughout the pacific islands should provide compelling testimony to the potency of the bahá'í Teachings through their manifest unity transcending tribal, national or ethnic barriers. The desperate search for solutions to the social and economic problems afflicting these countries is tempting people, in increasing numbers, to indulge in partisan political activities; the indigenous bahá'ís should refuse to be drawn into such divisive pursuits and should strive to acquire a more profound insight into the nature of the world order of bahá'u'lláh, which offers a pattern for a future society distinguished by justice and unity, far removed from the contention of competing political interests.

in many of the nations of your area, women have traditionally been restricted to a secondary role in the life of society. we call upon the

224-2. jTA, p. 89.224.3

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528bahá'í women of these countries, assured of the support and encouragement of all elements of the bahá'í community, to demonstrate the transforming power of this revelation by their courage and initiative in the teaching work and their full participation in the administrative activities of the faith.

in much of the region, insufficient attention has been given to the education of children. far more extensive programs should be initiated in those countries where the need exists, to ensure that bahá'í children are nurtured, encouraged to acquire trained minds, illumined with a sound knowledge of the divine Teachings, well-equipped to participate in the work of the cause at all levels and to contribute to the arts, crafts and sciences necessary for the advancement of civilization. Such programs, when open to all children, bahá'í or not, offer a potent means of extending the beneficial influences of

bahá'u'lláh's message to the wider society.

in Northeastern Asia, the progress of the faith has been most encouraging, and a good foundation has been laid for the bahá'ís of japan and korea to magnify the size of their communities substantially during the four year plan, while making a notable contribution to the work of the faith in neighboring countries. Special attention should be given to the development of the faith in the ryukyu islands and also to the exploration of any

opportunities which might arise to carry the healing message of bahá'u'lláh to all parts of the Korean peninsula.

The dedication and vitality of the bahá'í community in the Philippine islands is a constant source of joy to us. We look to the Filipino believers to make a significant advance in the process of entry by troops during the four year plan, while giving renewed attention to the strengthening of their local Spiritual Assemblies and the development of community life. This will necessitate the intensive use of training institutes throughout the country, and the involvement of a larger number of believers in these training programs. The members of this devoted bahá'í community provide a welcome source of manpower for the reinforcement of bahá'í endeavors elsewhere, particularly in the Asian and Pacific regions.

We are well aware of the restrictions which have long afflicted the members of the Indonesian bahá'í community. Their staunchness of faith, and their initiative in taking full advantage of whatever opportunities are open to them, attract our admiration and gratitude. We urge them to continue their endeavors throughout the whole of Indonesia, with full confidence that their hopes will be fulfilled in the future.^{224.6}

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529A special responsibility must rest upon the believers in Papua New Guinea, constituting the largest body of bahá'ís in Australasia, to strive unceasingly to build a vibrant community which embraces all strata of society and which is renowned as a dynamic and enlightened segment of their nation. We look forward, in the course of the four year plan, to a greater participation of the bahá'í men and women of this country in the development of the faith in other parts of Melanesia and elsewhere throughout the Pacific islands. In Australia, New Zealand and Hawaii, there are well-established and soundly functioning bahá'í communities, each characterized by an admirable record of accomplishments on the home front and by a notable contribution to the work of the faith in other parts of the Pacific and beyond.

we call upon the believers in these countries to strive for a fuller realization of their duty to advance the interests of the faith on the home fronts and throughout the length and breadth of the pacific region. in their own countries, they should aspire to far greater attainments, marked by a substantial increase in the number of adherents and an enhanced public awareness of the distinctive character of the bahá'í faith and its followers. They can render invaluable assistance to other bahá'í communities, not only in the pacific region but in Southeast Asia and beyond, because of the experience they have acquired in the teaching and administrative fields and the resources to which they have access. The believers from the pacific islands who have taken up residence in these three countries should be mindful of the responsibilities which rest upon them to devise means by which they can contribute to the strengthening of the bahá'í communities in the island nations from which they have come. many of the valiant bahá'í communities of the pacific islands are distinguished by the fact that they constitute significant percentages of the populations of their countries. The believers in these island nations need to direct their attention, more than ever, to the propagation of the faith. They should also concentrate on the development of a distinctive community life, based on an uncompromising adherence to the precepts of the faith, and guided by well-functioning local Spiritual Assemblies, which will demonstrate to the entire populations of their countries the unifying and transforming power of the faith, and will attract to the cause a multitude of new believers. Through this effort, they can make a vital contribution to enhancing the worldwide prestige of the faith, and can lay the foundation for even more outstanding victories in the future. we urge them to give attention to sharply increasing their level of international cooperation in 224.10

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50pursuit of the goals of the four year plan, including support of the establishment of a strong bahá'í community in french polynesia as a basis for the future election of a National Spiritual Assembly there.

Almost four decades have passed since Shoghi effendi described the pacific region in which you live as “that vast area of the globe, an area endowed

with unimaginable potentialities, and which, owing to its strategic position, is bound to feel the impact of world-shaking forces, and to shape to a marked degree through the experience gained by its peoples in the school of adversity, the destinies of mankind."

224-3 Since that time your nations have come ever more fully under the influence of the forces which are causing turmoil and disorder to human society, while the followers of bahá'u'lláh have labored, undeterred and with admirable dedication, to advance the cause of their lord and to establish his institutions. The pacific area, where, as the guardian stated, "b ahá'í exploits bid fair to outshine the feats achieved in any other ocean, and indeed in every continent of the globe. . .,"224-4 now stands at the threshold of victories far greater than any yet won. we call upon you to go forward now as never before, assured of our ardent prayers in the h oly Shrines on your behalf, confident of your ultimate triumph.

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Our Sacred Duty to Teach the Faith
and the Role of the Institutions

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]